

As for the professional or semiprofessional real estate investor, in order to have any hope of success, he must have knowledge of a vast range of subjects running the alphabetical gamut from architecture to zoning laws. He should also retain a much-better-than-average lawyer. If it's true that possession is nine points of the law, it's equally true that nine tenths of the problems involved in the possession of real property are legal ones.

It's not possible to list any specific, universally applicable rules to guide the real estate investor. There are far too many different types of real property—ranging from single lots in uninhabited areas to entire complexes of residential, industrial or commercial buildings. The rules investors follow—or should follow—vary widely according to the type of property involved, the use which is to be made of it and local and even individual considerations.

Nonetheless, there *are* some general rules and pointers which provide a valuable checklist of things to do—and not to do—for anyone who is thinking of making an investment in any kind of real estate.

1. Make a thorough study of the real estate market and its prospects in your area before you buy. Naturally, you should seek to buy when prices are low and the indications are that values will rise. Always take into consideration such

factors as the rate of population increase and the general prospects of business in the area. There is no quicker way to lose money in real estate than by investing it in property located in declining areas.

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2. Know or learn as much as possible about every aspect of the particular use to which you intend putting the property you wish to buy. In other words, don't buy a house unless you're certain that it's suited to the requirements of your family and that it's well built. Don't plan on having a house built unless you know something about building—or at the very least until you've found an architect and a building contractor in whom you have complete confidence.